

57, Gordon Square,

L o n d o n, W.C.1.

14th September 1917.

Dear Sir,

I am much interested by your reconstruction of my passage about thought. You say that you would like to know in what way your reconstruction "fails to express my meaning."

The logical meaning is, of course, unchanged, but what is lost is the movement and rhythm. In a passage of this kind, one instinctively develops a theme in the kind of way in which Beethoven does. One works it gradually free from antagonistic feelings, until at the end it emerges triumphant. This, of course, effects the whole rhythm of the sentences and the changes in the cadences. I do not mean that all this is deliberate or conscious: indeed it is only through comparing it with your reconstruction that I become aware of a certain crescendo in the original, which I feel to be lacking in your reconstruction. You begin with the triumph and end with the terror, which would suggest thought as a tyrannic master rather than an inspiring leader into freedom.

The effect of your reconstruction would be, to my mind, that thought is great but man is not worthy of it, whereas the effect that I wish to give is that man can grow great through thought.

Perhaps this is all fanciful on my part. I am sorry St. Paul's reply cannot be obtained.

It seems to me a most admirable method of teaching boys what is good and bad in style, but I think in good writing the rhythmical development has to keep pace with the development in ideas, and above all the last cadence should embody the emotion of the principal idea. If one wished to bring out the littleness of man, one would have quite a different kind of cadence, like that of

It is a tale
Told by an idiot, full of sound and fury,
Signifying nothing.

I am much honoured that you should have thought anything of mine worthy of this kind of treatment. But it is hard on anyone to be brought into immediate juxtaposition with the passage on Charity, unless, indeed, this passage should produce charity in the reader.

Yours truly,